

IN VICTORY THEY TRUST
Gujarat state BJP chief C.R. Paatil (fifth from left) with BJP leaders at Navagam, Apr. 7

build on past gains, especially in the 2017 assembly polls, when the BJP was reduced to 99 seats and the Congress won 77. That upset was triggered by the Patidar reservation movement led by Hardik Patel. However, BJP voters returned to the saffron fold, including Hardik himself, before the next election. Reflecting on the party's slide, a veteran Congress leader blames a deep-rooted culture of nepotism, a stunted leadership in the '90s and beyond, and the loss of grassroots connection.

THE CONGRESS FAILED TO BUILD ON GAINS IN THE 2017 ASSEMBLY POLLS, WHEN IT WON 77 SEATS. THEN BJP VOTERS RETURNED TO THE SAFFRON FOLD

Development work undertaken by the BJP governments that have cemented the party's hold are not hard to list. For example, the Narmada canal network has reached out to the far corners of north Gujarat, including Kutch and Saurashtra, that were earlier dependent on rainwater. The BJP has reaped the immense goodwill generated from this. Then there are the pet projects of PM Modi—GIFT City, Dholera Industrial City, Delhi-Mumbai Industrial Corridor and expansion of ports—that led to breakneck infrastructure development and improved road connectivity. These projects have hiked real estate prices across the state.

There has also been a perception of security and trust in the law and order mechanism among voters. Though there is polarisation, as evidenced by the increase since 2002 of notified "disturbed areas" where real estate deals between Hindus and Muslims are governed by the Disturbed Areas Act—thus deepening segregation of the communities—incidents of communal riots have markedly decreased.

The stable functioning of the Gujarat government, too, has inspired confidence. The key to this are retired IAS officers running the administration without interference. Between 2014 and 2022, former bureaucrat K. Kailashnathan ran the show as chief principal secretary in the chief minister's office. In December 2022, two more retired officers, Hasmukh Adhia and S.S. Rathore, were appointed as advisors to the CM. ■

DARJEELING

Backseat Drivers

At stake is not just one LS seat, the results will also reveal who has maximum clout among the Gorkhas—Bimal Gurung, Anit Thapa or Ajoy Edwards

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar *in Darjeeling*

RAJWANT RAWAT



TWICE LUCKY?
Sitting MP and BJP candidate Raju Bista

It is a pleasant 20-24 degrees centigrade in Darjeeling—the erstwhile summer capital of the Raj and a popular tourist destination in north Bengal—even as the rest of the state and the country brace for an intense summer. The mild weather, however, can do little to cool the heat of the general election, as political parties and candidates gear up for a pitched battle in this Lok Sabha seat nestled in the foothills of the Himalaya. The constituency, comprising parts of Uttar Dinajpur, Kalimpong and Darjeeling districts, goes to the polls on April 26. The key players are Bimal Gurung—the former face of the Gorkhaland Movement which remains the most important political issue here—his one-time deputy Anit Thapa, and Ajoy Edwards, owner of the town's iconic Glenary's bakery and restau-